

Germany Itinerary

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Berlin in a Day: A Polish-Jewish Guide, Checkpoint Charlie & the Weight of a City

Some cities you walk through. Berlin you *argue* with. From the moment we landed on the morning of **15th August**, the city was already negotiating with us — first via a one-hour immigration queue, then via a Polish-Jewish tour guide who refused to call Hitler by his name. By night, we were sitting in a hostel garden with a German beer-and-lemonade mix called *Radler*, two scoops of gelato earlier than dinner, trying to fit the day into one sentence. We couldn't. Berlin doesn't fit.

Day 1: 15th August

Arrival, the Immigration Queue & a Hostel in Mitte

We landed in Berlin to the kind of immigration queue that quietly eats your buffer. **An hour later** we were finally outside, hauling bags onto the S-Bahn and watching East Berlin's low brick blocks scroll past. By the time we checked into the hostel and dropped luggage, the morning was gone — and the only sensible response was to walk straight out into it.

Two scoops of **gelato** on a footpath before lunch. A coffee for ballast. We had booked a free walking tour on **GuruWalk** for the early afternoon and were quietly hoping it would do what the best tours do: take a city that intimidates you and make it small enough to hold in one hand.

Day 1

A Polish-Jewish Guide & the Story Berlin Refuses to Hide

Our guide on the **GuruWalk free tour** was a Polish-Jewish woman who had moved to Berlin years ago. She walked us through three hours of the city without ever once saying the name Hitler. She called him "*the man*", "*the Austrian painter*", "*he-who-must-not-be-named*." Half-joking, fully serious. "**In our family,**" she said at the Holocaust Memorial, "**we don't give him the dignity of a name. Think of him as Voldemort. He doesn't deserve more.**"

That framing — Voldemort, not history-book villain — did something nothing in a museum had managed. It made the city's weight personal. We walked between the **2,711 concrete slabs** of the Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe in near silence. The ground dips as you go in; the blocks rise above you; the city sounds fade. You come out the other side a slightly different shape.

"In our family, we don't give him the dignity of a name. Think of him as Voldemort." A Polish-Jewish guide, walking us through her own family's grief, somewhere between the Memorial and the Brandenburg Gate. That sentence is the Berlin we carried home.

The tour wound past the **Reichstag**, the location of the **Führerbunker** (now a nondescript car park — Berlin deliberately refused to memorialise it), the spot where the Wall once cut the city in half, and bits of pavement embedded with *Stolpersteine* — the small brass "stumbling stones" marking the last freely-chosen home of someone killed in the Holocaust. You stop. You read a name. You walk on. The city wants you to do exactly that.

Day 1

A Döner Break at Checkpoint Charlie

Halfway through, the tour paused at **Checkpoint Charlie** — the Cold War crossing point between East and West Berlin, now a piece of touristic theatre with actors in fake military uniforms posing for €5

photos. We didn't care. We were starving, and there was a **döner** shop on the corner whose queue told us everything we needed to know.

Vegetarian döner in Berlin is one of the great unsung travel meals — warm flatbread, halloumi or falafel, pickled cabbage, garlic-yoghurt, chilli oil that means it. We ate standing on the pavement, watching tourists pose with the fake guards, the museum of escape attempts looming behind. The juxtaposition felt entirely Berlin: tragedy and street food at the same intersection, both taken seriously.

Day 1

Brandenburg Gate & the Last Light

The tour ended at the **Brandenburg Gate**, late afternoon, the stone glowing the kind of gold that Instagram can't quite fake. We did the photo. We tipped our guide generously — and meant it. Then we walked, no plan, towards the Tiergarten, the way you do when a city has worn you out emotionally and your legs are the only part still willing to participate.

Back at the hostel, the garden was full of travellers doing nothing in particular. We bought two bottles of **Radler** — beer cut with lemonade, sweet, low-strength, exactly right for a day with more thoughts than answers — and sat on a wooden bench until it was dark. Berlin was loud somewhere else. In that garden, for an hour, it was finally quiet.

Must-Visit in Berlin (in One Day)

- **GuruWalk Free Tour:** Pick the Third-Reich / Cold War walk. Tip well.
- **Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe:** Walk between the slabs. No photos.
- **Brandenburg Gate:** Late afternoon gold; best with the Reichstag behind you.
- **Checkpoint Charlie:** Skip the photo, eat the döner on the corner.
- **Reichstag dome:** Free, but book the slot online days in advance.
- **Stolpersteine:** Look down as you walk — Berlin's most quietly powerful memorial.
- **Hostel garden + Radler:** Cheapest way to decompress from the day.

Hamburg in One Day: Elbphilharmonie, Beatles in Iron & a 2 a.m. FlixBus

Hamburg was meant to be a sidestep — a one-day breath between Berlin and a midnight FlixBus to Copenhagen. We arrived on **16th August** with luggage on our backs, a tripod stand left behind in the hostel (the first of two mistakes I'd kick myself for that week), and the kind of weather that justified Germany's nickname for Deutsche Bahn — "*Delayed Bahn*." We left Hamburg twelve hours later with sea spray in our hair, Beatles statues photographed, a carnival under our feet, and a 2 a.m. coach pulling up in the dark.

Day 1: 16th August

A Day Trip With All Our Bags on Our Backs

The train from Berlin to Hamburg was, predictably, delayed. We had joked about "*Delayed Bahn*" the night before; the universe, predictably, took notes. The plus side: it gave us time to realise I had left the **tripod stand** at the Berlin hostel. The minus side: we'd already paid for it. Travel teaches you to forgive yourself out loud, in public, on a platform — and then keep walking.

We arrived at **Hamburg Hauptbahnhof** mid-morning, stored both suitcases in the station **luggage lockers** (cheap, easy, life-saving on a day-trip), and stepped out into a city that smelled of harbour, rain on cobble, and bakery yeast all at once. With no hotel to drop into and a midnight bus to catch, the city had to fit into ten hours. Hamburg, generously, agreed.

Day 1

The Music Centre by the Port — Elbphilharmonie

First stop: the **Elbphilharmonie**, Hamburg's glass-and-wave concert hall sitting like a docked ship on top of an old red-brick warehouse. We weren't there for a concert — we were there for the **Plaza**, the free public viewing terrace eight floors up, reached by a long curved escalator that feels like an art piece in itself.

From the Plaza, the city opens out: **HafenCity**, the working port with its container cranes lined up like sleeping animals, the Speicherstadt warehouses below, the Elbe river curving away into industrial distance. It was the kind of view that made me wish — once again — for the tripod still sitting in Berlin. We took the photo handheld, slightly tilted, slightly perfect.

I left the tripod in Berlin. The Plaza of the Elbphilharmonie was where I forgave myself for it — because some views are better when you have to brace your elbows on a railing and just *look*.

Day 1

The Beatles in Iron, a Carnival Like Home

From the port we walked into **St. Pauli** and the start of the **Reeperbahn** — where the **Beatles Platz** sits at the junction. Five iron silhouettes of John, Paul, George, Stuart (their original bassist) and a composite Pete/Ringo drum kit, cut flat from sheet metal, ankle-deep in a stylised vinyl-record pavement. We took photos with each of them like teenagers. Hamburg is where the Beatles made themselves into the Beatles, playing 8-hour club sets along this street before fame found them. It felt right to be quietly silly about it.

And then, unexpectedly, a **carnival**. The *Hamburger Dom* funfair was on — Germany's largest folk festival, three times a year on the Heiligengeistfeld — and we walked straight into it without planning. Ferris wheel, fried-dough stalls, sugar-roasted almonds, a haunted house, families everywhere. For a moment it felt like a winter *mela* back home in India — same noise, same lights, same sticky-fingered children running between rides — just colder, and with pretzels instead of jalebis.

Day 1

A 2 a.m. FlixBus & a Father Carrying His Son

Dinner was something quick and warm near the station. Then the long wait — the bags collected, the platform changed twice, the bench made into a temporary home. Our **FlixBus to Copenhagen** pulled in just past **2 a.m.**, the kind of hour that strips a city down to the people who really have to be there.

Boarding behind us was a young father carrying his sleeping son like a folded blanket, the boy's head dropped on his shoulder, his small backpack swinging from the father's free hand. The father caught my eye and gave the small, tired smile parents give other tired travellers at 2 a.m. We tucked into our window seats, the bus pulled away from Hamburg, and the last thing I saw before sleep was the Elbphilharmonie's lights dropping behind us into the dark.

Must-Visit in Hamburg (in One Day)

- **Hauptbahnhof luggage lockers:** Day-trip with everything? Use these.
- **Elbphilharmonie Plaza:** Free 360° view; ride the curved escalator up.
- **Speicherstadt walk:** Red-brick UNESCO warehouses, dark canal water.
- **Beatles Platz, St. Pauli:** Five iron silhouettes; photo with each.
- **Hamburger Dom (in season):** Three times a year. Walk-in, no ticket.
- **HafenCity waterfront:** Best at golden hour, even with no plan.
- **FlixBus night routes:** Cheap Berlin↔Hamburg↔Copenhagen sleep-on-board legs.

Munich: Neuschwanstein Castle, Beer Gardens & Bavaria's Proud Identity

Bavaria doesn't feel quite like the rest of Germany—and Bavarians will be the first to tell you so. Munich, the state capital, carries its regional identity with a very particular confidence: the lederhosen worn unironically, the beer culture treated as heritage rather than tourism, the Alps visible on clear days from the city's parks. We arrived for the final leg of our Germany trip and immediately felt the shift in atmosphere. More relaxed. More festive. More openly proud.

We had three full days in Munich and used every hour, including a day trip that we'd been looking forward to since we booked the flights months earlier: **Neuschwanstein Castle**.

Day 1

Neuschwanstein — The Fairytale That Inspired Disney

Neuschwanstein Castle sits in the Bavarian Alps above the village of Hohenschwangau, and it is genuinely, objectively one of the most beautiful buildings humans have created. King Ludwig II commissioned it in 1869, and though he died before its completion, what he created became the template for every subsequent fairytale castle—including, famously, the inspiration for Sleeping Beauty's Castle in Disneyland.

We took the train from Munich Hauptbahnhof to Füssen (about 2 hours), then a bus up to the castle ticket office. *Book your timed entry tickets in advance*—we cannot stress this enough. The queues for on-the-day tickets are brutal in summer. We'd booked weeks ahead and walked straight in.

Standing at the Marienbrücke bridge above Neuschwanstein, with the castle emerging from mist and pine forest, the Alps behind it catching morning light—this was the image I'd held in my imagination since childhood. Reality exceeded it.

The interior tour takes about 35 minutes and reveals rooms of extraordinary ambition: the Singers' Hall modeled on Parsifal's Grail Castle, Ludwig's bedroom covered in elaborate Gothic woodcarving that took craftsmen four years to complete, and everywhere the symbols of swans and Wagnerian mythology that Ludwig was obsessed with. He lived in the castle for just 172 days before his death under mysterious circumstances.

Day 2

Marienplatz & the Glockenspiel

Back in Munich proper, **Marienplatz** is the historic heart of the city—a large pedestrian square flanked by the Gothic **Neues Rathaus** (New Town Hall), with its famous **Glockenspiel**: a 43-bell carillon with 32 life-sized figures that perform daily at 11 a.m. and noon. We positioned ourselves in the crowd at 11, watched the figures dance and joust through two stories of Bavarian legend, and then joined the very satisfied tourists shuffling off to get coffee.

Around the square, the **Viktualienmarkt**—Munich's daily outdoor food market—has been operating since 1807. We ate the most perfect **weißwurst** (white sausage) with sweet mustard, accompanied by a pretzel the size of a dinner plate, at a market stall. Locals were doing the same, which felt like sufficient endorsement.

Day 2

English Garden — Larger Than Central Park

The **Englischer Garten**—English Garden—is one of the world's largest urban parks, larger than New York's Central Park. On a warm June day, it's essentially where all of Munich goes to exhale. People swimming in the **Eisbach**, a cold fast-moving stream running through the park (the river surfers at the Haus der Kunst end of the stream are a genuine Munich institution). People cycling. People lying in grass that seemed specifically designed for lying in.

We found a **Biergarten** inside the park—one of four, because of course there are four—and ordered from the traditional self-service setup: you get your beer and food from different counters, find a table, arrange your life. The beer was cold, the pretzels were warm, the afternoon was golden. Bavaria at its most straightforwardly delightful.

Day 3

Dachau — The Historical Weight Munich Carries

We made the decision to visit the **Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial Site**, about 20 km from central Munich by S-Bahn. We weren't sure whether to include it in a travel guide, but then—we were in Germany, visiting history honestly, and Dachau was Germany's first concentration camp, opened in 1933.

The memorial is free, thoughtful, and unflinching. We spent three hours there. We didn't photograph inside the main memorial building. We walked the length of the grounds where prisoners lived and died. And we came back to Munich quieter, and perhaps more grateful, than we'd left.

Both the lightness of the Biergarten and the gravity of Dachau are parts of what Munich contains. We think it's worth holding both.

Must-Visit Places in Munich & Bavaria

- **Neuschwanstein Castle:** The original fairytale fortress.
- **Marienplatz & Glockenspiel:** Munich's historic heart.
- **Viktualienmarkt:** Daily food market since 1807.
- **English Garden Biergarten:** Afternoon beer in a park bigger than Central Park.
- **Eisbach River Surfing:** Watch locals surf a city river wave.
- **Nymphenburg Palace:** Baroque summer residence of Bavarian royals.
- **Deutsches Museum:** World's largest science & technology museum.
- **Dachau Memorial Site:** Essential historical responsibility.

Stuttgart: Fast Cars, Hillside Vineyards & the Slowest Sunday

Stuttgart wasn't on our original radar. We added it to our Germany itinerary somewhat on a whim—a gap to fill between Frankfurt and Munich, a name on a map. And then it became one of the most surprising cities of the trip. Stuttgart is confident without being loud. It's a city that knows what it's good at: engineering, wine, and the kind of comfortable quality of life that doesn't need to advertise itself.

It's the birthplace of the automobile, home to two of the world's most celebrated car museums, and somehow also a city of hillside vineyards, half-timbered old-town streets, and some of the warmest locals we met anywhere in Germany.

Day 1

Mercedes-Benz Museum — A Love Letter to Motion

We spent an entire morning at the **Mercedes-Benz Museum**, and we are not car people in any meaningful sense. Yet we were completely captivated. The building itself—a double-helix structure with two spiraling ramps winding through 160 years of automotive history—is architectural theater before you've seen a single vehicle.

The exhibits begin in 1886 with the Benz Patent Motor Car, the first true automobile, and wind through racing history, wartime utility vehicles, concept cars, and futurism. The racing room—engines suspended from the ceiling, trophies gleaming—had Harshit practically pressing his nose against the glass of vintage Formula One cars. I was more interested in the social history: how the car changed cities, labor, family life, independence. How a machine altered everything about how humans move through the world.

We discovered that Stuttgart sits in a valley ringed by vine-covered hills, and that those vineyards? They stretch right to the city's edge, tended for centuries, producing wines that Württemberg locals are quietly proud of and visitors often never discover.

Day 1

Porsche Museum — Pure Speed, Perfectly Curated

The **Porsche Museum** is smaller and more focused than Mercedes—80 vehicles, meticulously selected, displayed in a building that appears to float above its supporting pillars. The approach is curatorial rather than encyclopedic. Every car here is either historically significant, technically groundbreaking, or both.

There are racing Porsches with extraordinary histories—Le Mans winners, hillclimb legends—alongside production cars that defined eras. A restored 356, the company's first. A 911 in its original form. The lineup of GT models that transformed the brand from sports car maker to endurance racing institution. And yes, we took the obligatory photographs pretending to own things we absolutely cannot afford.

Day 2

Vineyard Walks Inside the City

What we hadn't expected from Stuttgart was nature this close to the centre. We walked up into the **Württemberg vineyard terraces**—accessible by foot or funicular—and found ourselves among rows

of vines with panoramic views over the valley below. In September, harvest season approaches and the air smells like must and warm stone.

We climbed to the **Württemberg Mausoleum**, a small classical rotunda sitting atop a hill surrounded by vineyards. Beautifully understated. The walk down through the vine rows, with Stuttgart's skyline in the distance and the valley turning golden in afternoon light, was worth every step.

Day 2

The Old Town & Schlossplatz

Stuttgart's historic centre was heavily bombed in WWII and rebuilt—so it's less medieval than many German cities—but the **Schlossplatz** (Palace Square) is grand and welcoming, with the Baroque New Palace on one side and the Jubilee Column in the centre. On warm evenings, half the city seems to gather here.

The nearby **Markthalle Stuttgart**—the covered food market—is one of Germany's most beautiful, a Jugendstil hall dating from 1914, selling regional produce, international specialties, and the kind of bread that makes you want to move somewhere with better loaves. We bought pretzels. We bought cheese. We ate standing up with wine in the market and felt genuinely content with our life choices.

Must-Visit Places in Stuttgart

- **Mercedes-Benz Museum:** 160 years of automotive history.
- **Porsche Museum:** Curated speed and racing legends.
- **Württemberg Vineyard Walk:** Vines inside city limits.
- **Württemberg Mausoleum:** Hilltop classical rotunda.
- **Schlossplatz:** Baroque palace square & city gathering point.
- **Markthalle Stuttgart:** Art Nouveau covered food market.
- **Killesberg Park:** Elevated gardens and hilltop views.
- **TV Tower (Fernsehturm):** World's first TV tower—views over the valley.

Black Forest & Triberg: Waterfalls, Cuckoo Clocks & Deep Forest Silence

The Black Forest was not what we expected, and everything we hoped for. We'd built it up in our imagination as a German fairy tale—dark trees, misty paths, the smell of pine and wood smoke. And while reality is rarely as cinematic as expectation, the **Schwarzwald** came closer than almost anywhere else on this trip.

We based ourselves briefly in **Freiburg im Breisgau**, a compact university city on the forest's southwestern edge—a lovely base for day trips into the hills. With a rented car and a vague plan, we set out along the **Schwarzwald Panoramastraße**, the scenic route that winds through villages, over passes, and into the deepest parts of the forest.

Day 1

Triberg — Germany's Waterfall Capital

Triberg is a small town that takes its waterfall reputation very seriously. The **Triberger Wasserfälle** are Germany's highest waterfalls—not by global standards dramatic, but genuinely beautiful: a series of cascades dropping 163 meters through moss-covered rock, with wooden walkways and viewing platforms that let you get almost close enough to feel the spray.

We hiked the path in the morning, with mist still hanging in the trees, and had the falls nearly to ourselves. By midday the tour buses arrive and it becomes considerably more crowded, so early arrival is strongly advised. The sound of the water through the forest—that constant white noise beneath the birdsong—was deeply, genuinely restorative.

We stood under a cuckoo clock the size of a small house and debated whether to buy one. We did not. But we ate Black Forest cake in the town that invented it, and that felt like more than enough.

Day 1

Cuckoo Clock Country

Triberg is also the epicentre of Germany's cuckoo clock industry, which began in the Black Forest in the 18th century. The town has shops selling clocks in every conceivable size—from pocket watches to grandfather clocks that announce the hour with the enthusiasm of an orchestra. There are museums about clock-making, workshops where you can watch craftspeople at work, and one shop that claims to house the world's largest cuckoo clock.

We browsed, admired, and left without purchasing. The shipping logistics of a large wooden clock seemed incompatible with our backpacks. But we spent a genuinely pleasant hour watching the mechanisms and learning about the regional craft history from a shop owner who had the air of someone who finds clocks infinitely more interesting than tourists—and was probably right.

Day 2

The Panorama Road & Mountain Villages

The real joy of the Black Forest is the drive itself. The **Schwarzwald Hochstraße**—the high road from Baden-Baden to Freudenstadt—winds through forest at elevations above 1,000 meters, offering views across the Rhine plain into France on clear days. Hairpin bends, villages that look like they emerged from a storybook, farmhouses with enormous pitched roofs that slope nearly to the ground to shed

heavy winter snow.

We stopped at **Lake Titisee**—a glacial lake ringed by forest, very popular and somewhat crowded in summer, but beautiful in the early light. Pedal boats and swimming spots and a promenade of cafés. We ate ice cream. We watched families navigate paddle boats with varying degrees of success. Normal, pleasant, European summer.

Day 2

Freiburg — Gateway City Worth a Half-Day

Freiburg itself deserves at least half a day. The **Münster cathedral** at its centre is extraordinary—arguably the most beautiful Gothic cathedral in Germany, having survived WWII bombing raids (while most of the surrounding city was destroyed). The spire is considered by architecture historians to be among the finest medieval towers in Europe.

The city also has a remarkable network of **Bächle**—narrow channels of flowing water that run alongside the streets, an ancient medieval drainage and fire-suppression system that the city has maintained because residents love them. Local legend says that if you accidentally step in a Bächle, you'll marry a Freiburger. We both stepped in one. Draw your own conclusions.

Must-Visit Places in the Black Forest

- **Triberger Wasserfälle:** Germany's highest waterfall cascade.
- **Schwarzwald Panoramastraße:** Scenic mountain highway.
- **Freiburg Münster:** Germany's most beautiful Gothic cathedral.
- **Lake Titisee:** Glacial forest lake for swimming & boats.
- **Cuckoo Clock Workshops:** Triberg craft heritage.
- **Freiburg Bächle:** Ancient water channels in cobblestone streets.
- **Feldberg Summit:** Highest peak in the Black Forest.
- **Black Forest Open Air Museum:** Traditional farmhouse history.

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